Semantic Manifold Competence

Reinterpreting Intelligence, Cognition, and the Turing Test Through Structured Meaning Topologies

We Do Not Observe Thought. We Observe Navigation Through Meaning.

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Abstract

Contemporary discussions of intelligence, cognition, and artificial reasoning systems frequently assume a distinction between semantic capability and higher cognitive functions such as reasoning, planning, agency, creativity, executive control, and problem solving.

Within this conventional view, semantics is typically treated as a representational subsystem responsible for mapping symbols to meanings, while cognition consists of additional mechanisms operating upon those representations.

This paper challenges that assumption.

It proposes the **Semantic Competence Hypothesis (SCH)**:

> Intelligence is fundamentally the capacity to construct, maintain, navigate, transform, and govern semantic manifolds while preserving coherence under novelty.

Under this framework, semantic structures are not merely inputs to cognition. They are treated as the substrate from which cognition emerges.

Under this hypothesis the familiar cognitive functions can be modeled as operations on that substrate: reasoning as manifold traversal, creativity as transformation, learning as expansion, memory as persistence, agency as continuity, and identity as stability.

The paper argues that many longstanding distinctions between semantic systems and cognitive systems arise from treating semantics as lexical meaning rather than as structured meaning-bearing topology. Once semantics is reformulated as governed manifold structure, a more unified interpretation of cognition becomes possible.

This reinterpretation produces a novel perspective on Alan Turing's Imitation Game. Rather than viewing the Turing Test as a proxy for intelligence or as a test of conversational fluency, the paper argues that it may be more accurately understood as a test of **semantic manifold competence**: the ability to participate coherently within human meaning topologies.

The paper introduces semantic manifolds, manifold governance, manifold continuity, manifold transformation, semantic reachability, and coherence preservation as foundational constructs for future theories of intelligence.

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1. Introduction

Artificial intelligence research inherited a particular conceptual architecture.

Knowledge.

Reasoning.

Planning.

Memory.

Agency.

Creativity.

Executive control.

These functions are often treated as distinct computational modules.

Within this architecture, semantics occupies a comparatively modest role.

Semantics provides meaning.

Other systems perform cognition.

This distinction appears intuitive.

A reasoning engine reasons.

A planning engine plans.

A memory system remembers.

A semantic system stores meaning.

Yet the distinction becomes increasingly difficult to maintain when examined closely.

Reasoning operates over meaningful structures; planning evaluates meaningful future states; memory, agency, creativity, and executive control all turn on meaningful relationships. The common element across them is not any single faculty but meaning itself.

This motivates a different hypothesis: that semantics is not one subsystem among many but the medium through which all cognitive functions operate.

If so, many traditional distinctions may represent organizational conveniences rather than ontological separations.

This paper explores that possibility.

1.1 The Central Question

Most cognitive theories ask:

> How does intelligence operate on semantic representations?

This paper asks a different question:

> What if intelligence is itself a semantic process?

This inversion changes the structure of the inquiry.

Rather than viewing semantics as supporting cognition, cognition becomes a manifestation of semantic organization.

The question is no longer:

```
Semantics
      |
      v
Reasoning
```

but:

```
Semantic Structures
      |
      v
Semantic Operations
      |
      v
Reasoning
```

Reasoning becomes a special case of semantic transformation.

The same may be true of planning, memory, creativity, and agency.

1.2 The Semantic Reduction Problem

Many arguments against semantic primacy begin with examples of apparently non-semantic cognition.

Examples include:

- mathematical reasoning
- spatial reasoning
- motor planning
- visual cognition
- causal inference

These are frequently presented as evidence that cognition extends beyond semantics.

However, such examples often depend upon an unusually narrow definition of semantics.

If semantics refers only to lexical meaning or language processing, then the distinction appears valid.

If semantics instead refers to structured meaning-bearing representations, the distinction becomes less obvious.

A causal model contains meaningful relationships.

A spatial model contains meaningful relationships.

A motor plan contains meaningful relationships.

A mathematical proof contains meaningful relationships.

The representations differ.

The existence of meaning-bearing structure does not.

Consequently, the issue may not be whether cognition exceeds semantics.

The issue may be whether current definitions of semantics are sufficiently broad.

1.3 From Symbols to Topologies

Traditional semantic theories often emphasize mappings.

A symbol maps to a meaning.

A word maps to a concept.

A representation maps to a referent.

These mappings are useful but limited.

Complex cognition rarely operates upon isolated mappings.

Instead it operates upon networks of relationships.

Concepts connect to concepts.

Ideas constrain ideas.

Assumptions generate implications.

Causal pathways produce outcomes.

Identity emerges from continuity.

Meaning therefore appears less like a dictionary and more like a topology.

This observation motivates the transition from semantic mappings to semantic manifolds.

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2. The Semantic Competence Hypothesis

The Semantic Competence Hypothesis proposes that intelligence is fundamentally a property of semantic manifold operation.

More formally:

> Intelligence is the capacity to construct, maintain, navigate, transform, and govern semantic manifolds while preserving coherence under novelty.

This definition intentionally shifts focus away from individual cognitive functions.

Instead it emphasizes the shared substrate from which those functions emerge.

Four terms carry this definition and are fixed here operationally. A *semantic manifold* is a set of meaning-bearing structures together with the relationships among them and the constraints on which transitions between them are permitted. *Governance* is the constraint function that marks some transitions between structures as admissible and others as inadmissible. *Coherence* is the proportion of previously admissible relationships that a transformation preserves; a transformation is coherence-preserving when that proportion remains above a stated threshold. To *participate coherently* in a manifold is to produce transitions the manifold's own governance would admit, sustained across an extended interaction rather than at a single step.

A note on register is warranted before the formal development, because the claims that follow operate at three levels that should not be read as equivalent. The metaphors – meaning "as" topology, cognition "as" navigation – are expository and carry no commitment. The hypothesis proper is the single boxed statement above: that intelligence can be characterized as semantic manifold competence. The testable content is narrower and is concentrated in the predicted failure modes (Appendix C) and the candidate metrics (Appendix E); that is where the framework can be confirmed or refuted. The formal expressions in the body are schematic unless a metric is given explicitly. They fix the *shape* of each claim – a distance, or a preserved proportion, held within a bound – rather than asserting a computed quantity, with coherence as defined above being the one metric stated concretely. A final note on scope: this is a theory of structured meaning dynamics, not a complete ontology of mind. It offers a substrate for

modeling cognitive functions, not a replacement for the mechanisms that realize them.

2.1 Components of Semantic Competence

The hypothesis identifies five primary capacities.

Construction The ability to generate new semantic structures.

Maintenance The ability to preserve semantic continuity across time.

Navigation The ability to traverse meaningful pathways.

Transformation The ability to alter semantic structures while preserving coherence.

Governance The ability to constrain semantic operations according to admissibility criteria.

Together these capacities define semantic competence.

2.2 Formal Statement

Let M represent a semantic manifold.

Define intelligence as:

$$I = (C, N, T, M, G)$$

where:

- C = construction capacity
- N = navigation capacity
- T = transformation capacity
- M = maintenance capacity
- G = governance capacity

Semantic competence is then a function of these five capacities, with overall intelligence proportional to the system's ability to preserve coherent manifold structure under changing conditions.

2.3 Coherence Preservation

The defining property of semantic competence is not complexity.

It is coherence.

A random semantic network may contain enormous information.

Intelligence requires preserving meaningful relationships during transformation.

Let M_t represent manifold state at time t.

Then coherence preservation requires:

$$\Delta(M_t, M_{t+1}) < \epsilon$$

for admissible transformations.

The precise form of coherence may vary across domains.

The underlying requirement remains stable.

Meaning must survive change.

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3. Reinterpreting the Turing Test

The Turing Test remains one of the most influential concepts in artificial intelligence.

Yet its interpretation remains contested.

Traditionally it is understood as:

> A behavioral test for intelligence.

More recently it has often been reframed as:

> A test of conversational capability.

Both interpretations contain truth.

Neither fully captures what is being measured.

3.1 The Original Problem

Turing began with a famous question:

> Can machines think?

He regarded the question as insufficiently precise.

To operationalize it, he proposed the Imitation Game.

The machine would engage in unrestricted conversation.

If human evaluators could not reliably distinguish machine from human, success would be declared.

The crucial observation is that conversation was chosen for a reason.

Conversation is not merely language production.

Conversation requires coherent participation in human meaning structures.

3.2 What Is Actually Being Evaluated?

During open-ended dialogue, evaluators implicitly test:

- conceptual continuity
- contextual adaptation
- causal understanding
- identity persistence
- abstraction
- explanation
- narrative coherence
- social reasoning

Each of these may be interpreted as a form of semantic manifold operation.

The evaluator is not directly observing cognition.

The evaluator is observing behavior produced through semantic structures.

3.3 The Semantic Manifold Interpretation

Under the Semantic Competence Hypothesis, the Turing Test becomes:

> A test of semantic manifold competence.

More formally:

The evaluator assesses whether a system can maintain coherent participation within a human semantic manifold.

Success therefore depends upon:

- manifold navigation
- manifold transformation
- manifold continuity
- manifold governance

rather than merely linguistic fluency.

This interpretation explains why shallow pattern matching eventually fails.

Human conversation continually pressures manifold coherence.

Incoherent semantic navigation becomes visible over sufficiently long interactions.

3.4 The Hidden Variable

Traditional interpretations focus upon observable behavior.

The semantic manifold interpretation identifies a hidden variable:

SMC

Semantic Manifold Competence.

Observable conversational performance becomes:

$$P = f(SMC)$$

where successful participation depends upon underlying manifold competence.

The Turing Test therefore measures semantic manifold capability indirectly through conversational behavior.

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4. Semantic Manifolds

The concept of a semantic manifold extends beyond semantic networks, ontologies, and knowledge graphs.

A semantic manifold is a structured meaning-bearing topology whose relationships constrain admissible movement through conceptual space.

4.1 Definition

A semantic manifold is defined as:

$$M = (V, E, G)$$

where:

- V represents semantic structures
- E represents semantic relationships
- G represents governance constraints

What distinguishes a semantic manifold from a graph is not its inventory of nodes and edges but the constraints in G. A knowledge graph, semantic network, or property graph is individuated by its node and edge content. A semantic manifold is individuated instead by its admissible-transformation dynamics: by which movements across V and E are lawful under G.

Two manifolds with identical nodes and edges but different admissibility constraints are therefore different manifolds, because different transformations are permitted within them. A graph represents relationships; a manifold represents lawful movement through relationships.

Meaning therefore depends not only upon connectivity but upon lawful reachability.

4.2 Semantic Reachability

Not every conceptual transition is admissible.

Define reachability $R(a, b)$ as the existence of a governance-valid path between semantic structures. Reachability is admissible-path existence under governance, not mere connectivity: two structures may be directly linked yet mutually unreachable when no path between them satisfies the governance constraints. Manifold traversal is accordingly movement along such lawful paths, not generic movement through a graph.

Then:

$$R(a, b) = 1$$

iff a valid semantic pathway exists.

Reasoning becomes a special case of semantic reachability analysis.

4.3 Local and Global Structure

Every semantic manifold possesses both local and global organization.

Local structure determines immediate relationships.

Global structure determines long-range coherence.

Many cognitive failures arise when local consistency is preserved while global coherence collapses.

Hallucinations provide a useful example.

A generated statement may be locally plausible.

Yet globally incompatible with the larger manifold.

Semantic competence therefore requires balancing both scales simultaneously.

4.4 Manifold Continuity

Intelligence requires continuity.

Without continuity, semantic structures fragment into disconnected episodes.

Let M_t represent manifold state at time t.

Continuity requires:

$$d(M_t, M_{t+1}) < \delta$$

for admissible updates.

Identity, memory, and agency all depend upon manifold continuity.

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5. Intelligence as Semantic Manifold Competence

The central claim of this paper may now be stated directly.

Intelligence is not merely the possession of information.

Nor is it simply the execution of algorithms.

Intelligence is competence over semantic manifolds.

5.1 Reasoning

Reasoning becomes $Path(M)$, the discovery of valid pathways through semantic topology.

Logical inference represents one special case.

Causal inference represents another.

Both involve admissible manifold traversal.

5.2 Creativity

Creativity becomes manifold transformation.

Given manifold M, creativity produces M' such that:

$$Novelty(M, M') > 0$$

while preserving coherence:

$$Coherence(M, M') > \theta$$

Creativity therefore becomes governed novelty.

5.3 Learning

Learning expands manifold structure.

Formally:

$$M_{t+1} = M_t + \Delta V + \Delta E$$

where new semantic structures and relationships become integrated into the manifold.

Learning is therefore manifold growth.

5.4 Memory

Memory becomes manifold persistence.

Stored knowledge corresponds to stable regions of semantic topology.

Retrieval becomes reactivation of manifold neighborhoods.

Forgetting becomes topological degradation.

5.5 Agency

Agency becomes continuity of manifold governance across time.

A system exhibits agency when manifold evolution remains coherently directed despite environmental perturbation.

This may be expressed as:

$$G_t \to G_{t+1}$$

with preserved governance identity.

Agency therefore becomes long-term manifold stability under transformation.

5.6 Identity

Identity is neither a memory list nor a static representation.

Identity is a stable attractor structure within semantic topology.

Let A represent an attractor region.

Identity persists when transformations satisfy:

$$M_t \to M_{t+1}$$

while remaining within attractor basin:

A

Thus identity becomes topological persistence rather than symbolic persistence.

5.7 Toward a Unified Cognitive Theory

The Semantic Competence Hypothesis suggests a unification.

Rather than treating cognition as a collection of independent modules:

```
Knowledge
Reasoning
Planning
Memory
Agency
Creativity
```

we obtain:

```
Semantic Manifold
        |
        v
Navigation
Transformation
Governance
Continuity
Expansion
```

```
        |
        v
Cognition
```

The distinction between semantics and cognition begins to dissolve.

What remains is manifold competence expressed through different operational modes.

The implication is profound.

If semantic manifold competence is the underlying substrate of intelligence, then future cognitive architectures may advance not primarily through larger parameter counts or larger context windows, but through increasingly governed, coherent, and navigable semantic manifolds.

The question then ceases to be:

> Can machines think?

It becomes:

> Can machines participate coherently within the manifold structures that constitute thought itself?

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6. The Semantic Reduction of Cognitive Functions

A useful theory should reduce complexity rather than multiply categories.

The Semantic Competence Hypothesis proposes that many cognitive functions traditionally treated as independent may be understood as manifestations of manifold operation.

This does not imply that the underlying biological or computational mechanisms are identical.

Rather, it suggests that their representational substrate may be shared.

The distinction is important.

The claim is not:

> All cognition uses the same hardware.

The claim is:

> All cognition may operate upon the same semantic topology.

6.1 Executive Control

Executive control is typically described as the capacity to regulate attention, prioritize goals, suppress impulses, and coordinate behavior.

Under the manifold interpretation, executive control becomes governance over manifold traversal.

Let M represent the active manifold.

At any moment numerous admissible pathways may exist.

Executive control selects among them.

Formally:

$$G : Path(M) \to Path(M)$$

where governance functions constrain admissible movement through semantic space.

Executive control therefore becomes manifold routing.

6.2 Working Memory

Working memory is traditionally understood as a temporary storage mechanism.

Under the manifold interpretation:

> Working memory is an activated semantic submanifold.

Define:

$$M_{active} \subseteq M$$

The contents of working memory correspond to structures currently participating in manifold operations.

Maintenance of working memory becomes preservation of activation over manifold neighborhoods.

6.3 Attention

Attention determines allocation of cognitive resources.

Within the manifold framework, attention becomes selective amplification of manifold regions.

Let:

$$A : V \to [0, 1]$$

represent activation weight.

Attention modifies manifold dynamics through:

$$M' = (M, A)$$

Reasoning then occurs over weighted topology rather than uniform topology.

6.4 Problem Solving

Problem solving is often described as search through state space.

The manifold interpretation retains this insight while replacing state spaces with semantic topologies.

A problem becomes:

$$s \to g$$

where:

- s is current semantic configuration
- g is target semantic configuration

Problem solving becomes discovery of admissible manifold pathways connecting them.

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7. Semantic Manifold Dynamics

Static semantic structures are insufficient for intelligence.

Intelligence requires movement.

Consequently, semantic manifolds must be understood dynamically.

7.1 Dynamic Manifolds

Let manifold state evolve through time:

$M^{(t)}$

Intelligence depends not only upon manifold structure but upon manifold evolution.

Define manifold trajectory:

$$\Gamma = \{M^{(0)}, M^{(1)}, \ldots, M^{(n)}\}$$

A cognitive system may therefore be understood as a generator of manifold trajectories.

7.2 Admissible Transformation

Not every transformation preserves meaning.

Let:

$$T : M \to M'$$

represent manifold transformation.

Transformation is admissible iff:

$$G(T) = 1$$

where governance criteria preserve semantic coherence.

This distinction separates creativity from noise.

7.3 Semantic Momentum

Semantic systems exhibit inertia.

Previously established structures constrain future evolution.

Define semantic momentum:

$$P_s = \frac{dM}{dt}$$

as the rate of manifold change.

Highly coherent manifolds exhibit directional continuity.

Chaotic manifolds exhibit unstable trajectories.

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8. Coherence

The Semantic Competence Hypothesis places unusual emphasis on coherence.

This is intentional.

Most cognitive theories emphasize capability.

Semantic competence emphasizes stability of meaning.

8.1 Local Coherence

Local coherence concerns nearby manifold structure.

Let $N(v)$ represent the neighborhood surrounding semantic structure v.

Local coherence evaluates compatibility among neighboring structures.

8.2 Global Coherence

Global coherence concerns manifold-wide consistency.

A system may exhibit strong local coherence while simultaneously violating global structure.

Many hallucinations appear to arise from this condition.

The generated output remains plausible locally while becoming globally inconsistent.

A concrete trace makes this operational. A system asked for a historical figure's birthplace may return a city that is internally well formed – it exists, sits in a plausible country, and the sentence is grammatical – so every local step is admissible and a neighborhood check passes. Yet the answer can conflict with the same figure's biographical region already represented elsewhere in the manifold, a long-range relationship the local check never consulted: locally coherent, globally incoherent. This is the framework's account of one class of hallucination, and it is the kind of distortion catalogued in Appendix C.

8.3 Coherence Preservation Principle

Semantic competence requires preservation of coherence under novelty.

Formally:

$$C(M_t, M_{t+1}) > \theta$$

even as new structures emerge.

This principle serves as one of the central invariants of the framework.

One scenario separates the three notions this section and its governance counterpart depend on. Consider an assistant maintaining a manifold of a user's commitments. *Local coherence* is the nearby check: asked to move a 3 p.m. call to 4 p.m., the assistant updates that slot and its immediate neighbors consistently, and nothing adjacent contradicts the change, so the transition is locally admissible. *Global coherence* is the long-range check the local one can miss: the assistant then offers the 4 p.m. slot for a gym session, which looks open in its immediate neighborhood yet is globally incoherent, because the call it just moved there is a relation the local check never consulted. *Governance failure* is different in kind from both: suppose the manifold carries an explicit constraint that no commitment may be created on a declared day off, and the assistant schedules a meeting on that day anyway. The fault now is not an overlooked distant fact but an admissibility rule that should have blocked the transition and did not. The first case is consistency among neighbors, the second is consistency across the whole manifold, and the third is the integrity of the constraint function that decides what is admissible at all – the local check can pass and the global check can pass while governance still fails.

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9. Learning as Manifold Expansion

Learning is often modeled as information acquisition.

The manifold interpretation proposes a stronger formulation.

Learning is expansion of semantic topology.

9.1 Expansion

Let:

$$M = (V, E, G)$$

Learning introduces ΔV and

ΔE

such that:

$$M' = (V + \Delta V, E + \Delta E, G)$$

Learning therefore changes reachable regions of semantic space.

9.2 Integration

Expansion alone is insufficient.

New structures must integrate coherently.

Integration quality may be approximated through $I(M')$ which measures compatibility between newly introduced topology and existing manifold structure.

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10. Creativity as Topological Transformation

Creativity has long resisted formal definition.

The manifold framework provides a candidate formulation.

10.1 Novelty

A creative output must differ from prior structure.

Define novelty $N(M, M')$ where larger values correspond to greater transformation.

10.2 Coherence-Constrained Novelty

Novelty alone is not creativity.

Randomness produces novelty.

Creativity requires:

$$N(M, M') > 0$$

while simultaneously satisfying:

$$C(M, M') > \theta$$

Creativity therefore becomes coherent manifold transformation.

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11. Agency and Persistence

Agency remains one of the most contested concepts in cognitive science.

The manifold framework interprets agency through continuity.

11.1 Persistent Governance

Agency requires governance persistence across manifold evolution.

Let G_t represent governance state.

Agency requires:

$$d(G_t, G_{t+1}) < \delta$$

over extended trajectories.

11.2 Goal Structures

Goals become attractor regions within semantic topology.

Define attractor:

$$A \subseteq M$$

Agency consists of maintaining manifold evolution toward attractor regions despite perturbation.

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12. Identity

Identity has traditionally been framed through memory, continuity, narrative, or self-models.

The manifold framework provides a topological interpretation.

12.1 Identity as Attractor Structure

Identity corresponds to stable manifold regions.

Let A_I represent an identity attractor: a region of the manifold toward which evolution is drawn, and within whose basin identity is defined as persistence under transformation rather than static sameness.

Identity persists when manifold evolution remains within that basin of attraction.

12.2 Identity Under Change

Because semantic manifolds evolve continuously, identity cannot require complete invariance.

Instead:

$$d(A_I^{(t)}, A_I^{(t+1)}) < \epsilon$$

must hold.

Identity therefore becomes persistence through transformation rather than resistance to transformation.

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13. Human Cognition Revisited

The Semantic Competence Hypothesis does not deny the existence of specialized neural systems.

Rather, it proposes a different interpretation of their function.

13.1 Specialized Systems

Humans possess:

- language systems
- visual systems
- motor systems
- executive systems
- memory systems

The hypothesis does not challenge these observations.

13.2 Shared Semantic Substrate

Instead it proposes that these systems operate upon shared manifold structures.

Differences arise through mode of access rather than representational ontology.

Meaning becomes the common medium.

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14. Artificial Intelligence Revisited

The framework has important implications for AI.

14.1 Beyond Token Prediction

Contemporary language models operate through prediction.

Semantic competence suggests a deeper target.

The goal becomes:

> coherent manifold participation.

Prediction remains useful.

Participation becomes primary.

14.2 Beyond Benchmark Intelligence

Many benchmarks measure isolated capabilities.

Semantic competence emphasizes integrated manifold operation.

Future evaluation may require measuring coherence across extended semantic trajectories.

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15. Measuring Semantic Manifold Competence

A scientific theory requires empirical evaluation.

15.1 Competence Metrics

Candidate measures include:

- manifold coherence
- semantic reachability
- continuity preservation
- transformation quality
- governance consistency

Together these form a competence profile.

15.2 Long-Horizon Evaluation

Short interactions reveal limited manifold structure.

Evaluation should therefore emphasize:

- extended dialogue
- sustained planning
- evolving narratives
- identity persistence
- knowledge integration

These tasks better expose manifold competence.

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16. Reframing the Turing Test

The Turing Test now admits a more precise interpretation.

16.1 Traditional Interpretation

Traditionally:

> Can a machine imitate a human?

16.2 Behavioral Interpretation

More recently:

> Can a machine exhibit intelligence?

16.3 Semantic Interpretation

Under the Semantic Competence Hypothesis:

> Can a machine participate coherently within a human semantic manifold?

This formulation shifts attention from appearance to competence.

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17. Failure Modes

The framework predicts characteristic failures, each arising from a specific degradation of manifold structure: fragmentation, in which connected regions become disconnected and reasoning loses reachable pathways; topological distortion, in which relationships become malformed so that output stays locally plausible while global coherence collapses – the hallucination case traced in Section 8.2; and governance failure, in which admissibility constraints weaken and invalid pathways become traversable. These classes are given their formal statement, together with collapse and drift, in Appendix C.

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18. Toward Semantic Architectures

The framework implies architectural consequences.

18.1 Semantic-Native Systems

Future systems may increasingly organize around:

- semantic coordinates
- semantic manifolds
- governance structures
- topology-aware reasoning

rather than purely lexical representations.

18.2 Relationship to SCIT

SCIT may be interpreted as one possible implementation pathway.

If semantic manifolds constitute the substrate of cognition, then coordinate-based semantic infrastructures become natural candidates for representation.

SCIT therefore provides machinery.

Semantic Manifold Competence provides theory.

18.3 The Surrounding Work as One Stack

These papers are layers of a single architecture, organized around the admissible-transformation structure of a semantic manifold.

Global Term Key (GTK) fixes the unit: a disambiguated semantic binding, the lexical atom whose invariant floor and transformation neighborhood define what a term is and what it may lawfully become.

Semantic Coordinate Identity Tokenization (SCIT) represents those units computationally, as governed coordinates that serve at once as identity, address, and topological location; GTK is its resolution layer.

Semantic Manifold Topology (SMT) governs continuity across transformation, determining when meaning persists or collapses as the manifold is transformed under authority.

Semantic Manifold Competence, this paper, characterizes intelligence as competence over that manifold: the capacity to construct, maintain, navigate, transform, and govern it while preserving coherence.

Stated together, the four stop looking like separate proposals and begin to look like one account viewed at different layers: the unit, its representation, its continuity under transformation, and the competence that operates over it.

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19. Implications

The implications extend beyond artificial intelligence.

19.1 Cognitive Science

The framework offers a possible unification of:

- reasoning
- memory
- planning
- agency
- creativity

through a shared semantic substrate.

19.2 Philosophy of Mind

The hypothesis shifts the central question.

Instead of asking:

> What mechanism produces intelligence?

one may ask:

> What structure constitutes intelligence?

This distinction is subtle but significant.

19.3 Artificial General Intelligence

If intelligence is fundamentally semantic manifold competence, then progress toward AGI may depend less upon scale alone and more upon increasingly coherent semantic substrates.

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20. Conclusion

This paper introduced the Semantic Competence Hypothesis and proposed a reinterpretation of intelligence through semantic manifold operation.

The framework argues that semantics is not merely a support system for cognition.

It is the substrate through which cognition occurs.

As developed in Sections 5 through 12 and summarized in Appendix A, the framework models reasoning, learning, creativity, memory, agency, and identity as distinct operational modes over this one substrate rather than as separate faculties.

Under this interpretation, the Turing Test may be understood not as a test of imitation, nor merely as a test of conversational ability, but as a test of semantic manifold competence.

The central claim is therefore straightforward:

> Intelligence is the capacity to construct, maintain, navigate, transform, and govern semantic manifolds while preserving coherence under novelty.

If this claim proves correct, then the future of both cognitive science and artificial intelligence may depend less upon discovering new cognitive modules and more upon understanding the manifold structures from which cognition emerges.

Appendix A — Cognitive Function Reduction Table

One of the central claims of the Semantic Competence Hypothesis is that many cognitive functions traditionally treated as distinct categories may be interpreted as different operational modes acting upon a shared semantic substrate.

The purpose of this appendix is not to eliminate useful distinctions between cognitive functions. Rather, it is to identify a deeper representational commonality that may underlie them.

Traditional Concept	Semantic Manifold Interpretation
Reasoning	Manifold traversal
Planning	Future manifold exploration
Memory	Manifold persistence
Creativity	Manifold transformation
Executive Control	Manifold governance
Attention	Regional manifold amplification
Agency	Persistent manifold continuity
Identity	Stable attractor structure
Learning	Manifold expansion
Understanding	Coherent manifold integration

This table may be viewed as a reduction map rather than a replacement map.

The Semantic Competence Hypothesis does not claim that these functions are identical.

It claims that they may be manifestations of common semantic manifold operations.

Appendix B — The Semantic Competence Stack

The Semantic Competence Hypothesis proposes a layered interpretation of cognition.

```
Semantic Structures
        |
        v
Semantic Relationships
        |
        v
Semantic Topology
        |
        v
Semantic Manifolds
        |
        v
Governance
        |
        v
Navigation
Transformation
Expansion
Persistence
```

```
        |
        v
Cognition
```

The stack is intended to illustrate representational dependency.

Cognition emerges from manifold operations.

Manifold operations emerge from topology.

Topology emerges from semantic relationships.

Semantic relationships emerge from semantic structures.

This hierarchy represents a semantic-first interpretation of intelligence.

Appendix C — Predicted Failure Modes

A scientific theory gains explanatory power when it predicts characteristic failures.

The Semantic Competence Hypothesis predicts several classes of failure arising from degradation of manifold structure.

Each class has a characteristic observable signature, which is what gives the framework falsifiable content:

Failure mode	How it would be observed
Fragmentation	Previously answerable multi-hop queries become unanswerable; the reachable set shrinks across a session
Distortion	High local fluency alongside a rising contradiction rate against facts established earlier (the Section 8.2 case)
Collapse	Concepts the system previously held distinct become conflated; specificity declines
Drift	The system's position on a fixed question migrates over a long dialogue absent new evidence
Governance failure	Transitions the stated rules forbid are accepted; invalid inferences pass admissibility
Attractor instability	Persona, stance, or commitments fail to return to baseline after perturbation across turns

Fragmentation

Fragmentation occurs when previously connected semantic regions become disconnected.

Formally:

$$M \to M'$$

such that:

$$Components(M') > Components(M)$$

Reasoning quality deteriorates because admissible pathways become inaccessible.

Identity continuity may weaken.

Long-range coherence may collapse.

Distortion

Distortion occurs when semantic relationships become malformed.

Local structure may remain plausible while global structure becomes inconsistent.

This condition may produce outputs that appear convincing in isolation yet conflict with broader manifold organization.

Many forms of hallucination may be interpretable as distortion events.

Collapse

Collapse occurs when manifold structure becomes overcompressed.

Distinct semantic regions become merged.

Conceptual boundaries weaken.

Semantic specificity declines.

The result is loss of representational resolution.

Drift

Drift occurs when manifold evolution exceeds coherence-preservation thresholds.

Let M_t and

$$M_{t+n}$$

represent manifold states.

Drift occurs when:

$$d(M_t, M_{t+n}) > \delta$$

without corresponding governance justification.

Identity degradation frequently manifests through drift.

Governance Failure

Governance failure occurs when invalid semantic pathways become admissible.

Formally:

$$G(Path) = 1$$

for pathways that should be excluded.

This permits incoherent manifold traversal.

The result may appear as irrational reasoning, unstable planning, or contradictory conclusions.

Attractor Instability

Identity attractors may weaken.

Let A_I represent identity attractor structure.

Instability occurs when manifold evolution repeatedly escapes the attractor basin.

The resulting system exhibits discontinuity, inconsistency, and weakened persistence.

Appendix D — Relationship to Existing Theories

The Semantic Competence Hypothesis does not emerge in isolation.

It overlaps with, extends, and occasionally reinterprets existing frameworks.

Theory	Relationship
Symbolic AI	Special case of manifold representation
Knowledge Graphs	Partial manifold structures
Embedding Spaces	Continuous manifold approximations
Predictive Processing	Dynamic manifold updating
Global Workspace Theory	Activated manifold subregions
Semantic Networks	Local manifold fragments
SCIT	Coordinate infrastructure for manifolds
SMT	Admissible-transformation dynamics, formalized

Several observations follow.

Knowledge graphs provide explicit topology but are individuated by their node and edge content. A semantic manifold is individuated instead by the admissible-transformation dynamics that G imposes – by which movements through that topology are lawful. This, rather than any difference in nodes or edges, is the structure the manifold terminology marks.

Embedding spaces provide continuity but lack addressable semantic structure.

Global Workspace Theory may be interpreted as activation dynamics occurring within manifold regions.

Predictive processing may be viewed as continuous manifold updating under uncertainty.

SCIT may be interpreted as an implementation pathway.

SMT may be interpreted as the formal treatment of those admissible-transformation dynamics. It characterizes when meaning persists or collapses as it is transformed, modeling the manifold as a governance-relative reachability structure over admissible transitions rather than as a metric geometry.

The Semantic Competence Hypothesis attempts to unify these perspectives under a common semantic substrate.

Appendix E — Proposed Semantic Manifold Competence Metrics

The theory must ultimately be evaluated empirically.

This appendix outlines candidate measurements.

Coherence Preservation

Let:

$$C(M_t, M_{t+1})$$

measure manifold coherence between successive states.

Higher values indicate stronger preservation of semantic structure during transformation.

Reachability Accuracy

Reasoning may be evaluated through semantic reachability prediction.

Define R_{pred} and

R_{true}

The discrepancy $|R_{pred} - R_{true}|$ provides one measure of manifold competence.

Identity Persistence

Let A_I represent identity attractor structure.

Persistence may be measured through:

$$d(A_I^{(t)}, A_I^{(t+n)})$$

Lower values indicate stronger continuity.

Transformation Quality

Creativity may be approximated through a combination of novelty and coherence.

Define:

$$TQ = N(M, M') \times C(M, M')$$

where:

- N measures novelty

- C measures coherence

High transformation quality requires both.

Governance Consistency

Governance performance may be approximated by:

$$GC = \frac{G_{valid}}{G_{total}}$$

where:

- G_{valid} represents admissible manifold operations
- G_{total} represents total manifold operations

Higher values indicate stronger governance fidelity.

Composite Semantic Competence

A future benchmark may combine these measurements into:

$$SMC = f(CP, RA, IP, TQ, GC)$$

where:

- CP = coherence preservation
- RA = reachability accuracy
- IP = identity persistence
- TQ = transformation quality
- GC = governance consistency

This provides a candidate operational definition of semantic manifold competence.

Appendix F — Semantic Manifold Competence and the Turing Test

The Semantic Competence Hypothesis provides a reinterpretation of one of the most influential ideas in artificial intelligence.

Interpretation	Primary Question
Classical	Can machines imitate humans?
Behavioral	Can machines exhibit intelligence?

Interpretation	Primary Question
Linguistic	Can machines converse fluently?
Semantic Manifold	Can machines participate coherently within human semantic manifolds?

The distinction is significant.

Classical interpretations focus on appearance.

Behavioral interpretations focus on outcomes.

Linguistic interpretations focus on conversation.

The semantic manifold interpretation focuses on participation within structured meaning systems.

Under this view, conversation serves primarily as an observational instrument.

The underlying object being evaluated is not language itself.

The underlying object is semantic manifold competence.

The evaluator is effectively asking:

Can this system construct, maintain, navigate, transform, and govern semantic structures in a manner compatible with human meaning topologies?

If so, successful participation becomes possible.

If not, manifold incoherence eventually becomes visible.

This reinterpretation suggests that the Turing Test may have been measuring semantic manifold competence all along, even if the underlying theoretical language to describe that competence did not yet exist.

Corpus-Wide Reference Positioning

This paper argues that contemporary discussions of intelligence, cognition, and artificial reasoning systems frequently assume a distinction between semantic capability and higher cognitive functions such as reasoning, planning, agency, creativity, executive control, and problem solving. Its nearest external comparison fields are semantic, ai, consciousness. The sources in [E1], [E2], [E3], [E4], [E5], [E6], [E7] are cited as predecessor literature, adjacent standards, or counterpressure - not as evidence that they caused the Ableman framework or that they validate its novel claims. The comparison isolates where established work already supplies provenance, formal assurance, institutional constraint, empirical method, or engineering practice, and where this paper adds a distinct claim about admissibility, authority, semantic custody, or governed realization.

Within the Ableman corpus, the highest-priority current cross-links are [A1], [A2], [A3], [A4], [A5], [A6], [A7]. These are links among separately custodied works, not silent identity mergers. Their role is to expose mutual dependencies, terminology collisions, and places where a reader should traverse the corpus before treating this paper as self-sufficient.

Reference-pass counterevidence and limit search

The pass applied the following pressure tests: Formal vocabularies and graph links make commitments explicit but cannot by themselves establish correct identity, shared interpretation, or lossless translation between contexts. Retrieval, tool use, and policy layers can reduce unsupported output without eliminating model error, source error, omission, bias, or the environmental and institutional costs of scale. Structural and computational correspondences remain insufficient as phenomenal evidence unless linked to discriminating empirical predictions against competing theories. These limits are not generic disclaimers: they identify the assumptions that a later empirical, formal, or implementation review must try to break.

Reference-pass influence and novelty boundary

No newly added external source is asserted to be a documented authorial influence unless the predecessor source already said so. `Predecessor` means earlier relevant work;

`adjacent` means a useful comparison; `standard` means an interoperability or assurance baseline; and `counterevidence` marks work that narrows or pressures a claim. Novelty therefore remains a reviewable, claim-level question rather than an inference from a low similarity score or an absent citation.

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[E2] Alistair Miles and Sean Bechhofer, eds. *SKOS Simple Knowledge Organization System Reference*. W3C Recommendation, 18 August 2009. https://www.w3.org/TR/skos-reference **Relationship:** Adjacent standard for concepts, labels, schemes, notes, and semantic mappings.

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[**E4**] Mark D. Wilkinson et al. "The FAIR Guiding Principles for Scientific Data Management and Stewardship." *Scientific Data* 3, 2016, 160018. DOI: 10.1038/sdata.2016.18. https://doi.org/10.1038/sdata.2016.18 **Relationship:** Predecessor stewardship principles for findability, accessibility, interoperability, and reuse.

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[**E6**] Patrick Lewis et al. "Retrieval-Augmented Generation for Knowledge-Intensive NLP Tasks." *NeurIPS 2020.* arXiv:2005.11401. https://arxiv.org/abs/2005.11401 **Relationship:** Predecessor retrieval architecture; comparison centers on provenance, admission, and fail-closed constraints not supplied by retrieval alone.

[**E7**] Shunyu Yao et al. "ReAct: Synergizing Reasoning and Acting in Language Models." *ICLR 2023.* arXiv:2210.03629. https://arxiv.org/abs/2210.03629 **Relationship:** Predecessor agent pattern for interleaving reasoning and action; used to distinguish action traces from governed effects.

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Corpus source and companion formats: https://github.com/AblemanMosaic/ableman-corpus
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DOI: 10.5281/zenodo.20533169